

HACKATHON QUALIFIER ROUND

Do's, Don'ts & PDF Submission Checklist

Purpose: This document is a participant-facing guide for the qualifier round. Participants should use it before submitting their idea/solution PDF. A technically good idea can still be rejected or downgraded if the submission is incomplete, unclear, unreadable, exceeds the file-size limit, or does not follow the required format.

1. QUALIFIER ROUND — WHAT IS EXPECTED

- Clearly understand the problem statement before proposing a solution.
- Explain the problem, target users, proposed solution, approach, and expected impact.
- Show that the idea is feasible within the hackathon's available time, resources, and technical capabilities.
- Keep the submission concise, structured, and easy for evaluators to review.
- Submit only the requested PDF/template and any explicitly requested supporting material.

2. PDF TEMPLATE — MANDATORY CHECKS BEFORE SUBMISSION

- Use the official hackathon PDF template if one has been provided.
- Do not remove required sections, headings, evaluation fields, declarations, or instructions from the template.
- Do not change the order of mandatory sections unless the organizers explicitly allow it.
- Complete every mandatory field. If a field genuinely does not apply, write "N/A" rather than leaving it blank.
- Keep team name, team members, contact information, and other identifiers consistent throughout the document.
- Make sure the problem statement/topic selected in the PDF exactly matches the assigned hackathon topic.
- Use a readable font size and clear headings. Avoid extremely small text just to fit more information.
- Check every page for cut-off text, overlapping elements, broken images, missing diagrams, or empty pages.
- Make sure tables, diagrams, screenshots, and flowcharts are readable at normal zoom.
- Verify that the final file opens correctly on another computer/device before uploading.
- Export/save the final document as PDF, not as an editable Word/PowerPoint file, unless another format is explicitly requested.
- Confirm the PDF file size is within the organizer's stated limit. Recommended hard check: ≤ 10 MB if the event instructions specify a 10 MB maximum.

3. RECOMMENDED CONTENT STRUCTURE

Section	What to include
1. Team Details	Team name, participant names, roles, college/organization if requested, and contact details.
2. Problem Statement	What problem are you solving? Who experiences it? Why is it important?
3. Existing Problem / Gap	Current limitations, pain points, inefficiencies, or gaps in existing solutions.
4. Proposed Solution	Your solution in simple terms. Explain what you are building and how it addresses the problem.
5. Key Features	List the most important features. Prioritize the features that directly solve the problem.
6. User Flow / Approach	Step-by-step flow of how a user/system will interact with the solution.
7. Technology / Architecture	Languages, frameworks, databases, APIs, AI/ML components, cloud/services, etc., where relevant.

Section	What to include
8. Feasibility	Why the solution can realistically be built during the hackathon; mention MVP scope.
9. Innovation / USP	What makes the idea different, useful, or better than obvious alternatives.
10. Expected Impact	Expected benefit to users/business/community, measurable outcomes if possible.
11. Future Scope	What could be added after the qualifier/MVP if time permits.

4. DO'S — STRONGLY RECOMMENDED

- ✓ **Do keep the problem specific.** Avoid broad statements such as “we will solve healthcare.” Define the exact problem.
- ✓ **Do explain the solution simply.** An evaluator should understand your idea without needing a separate explanation.
- ✓ **Do focus on the MVP.** State what you can realistically demonstrate in the hackathon.
- ✓ **Do use diagrams when they improve understanding.** A simple architecture or user-flow diagram can communicate faster than a page of text.
- ✓ **Do justify technology choices.** Mention why a particular technology is useful instead of listing technologies just to look advanced.
- ✓ **Do quantify impact where possible.** Use measurable goals such as reduced processing time, improved accuracy, lower cost, or faster response.
- ✓ **Do proofread.** Check spelling, grammar, team names, numbers, URLs, and technical terms.
- ✓ **Do maintain consistency.** If the solution is called “Project X” on page 1, do not call it “Project Y” later.
- ✓ **Do test the final PDF.** Open it after export and inspect every page.
- ✓ **Do keep a backup.** Save the editable source document separately, but submit the final PDF as instructed.

5. DON'TS — AVOID THESE MISTAKES

- ✗ **Don't exceed the file-size limit.** If the organizer specifies 10 MB, a PDF above 10 MB should not be submitted.
- ✗ **Don't submit an unfinished draft.** Remove comments, tracked changes, placeholder text, and internal notes.
- ✗ **Don't leave mandatory fields blank.**
- ✗ **Don't add irrelevant content.** More pages do not automatically mean a better submission.
- ✗ **Don't use excessive design.** Avoid backgrounds, decorative elements, and colors that reduce readability.
- ✗ **Don't use screenshots as a substitute for explanation.** Screenshots should support the idea, not replace the solution description.
- ✗ **Don't claim features you cannot realistically implement.** Overpromising can hurt credibility.
- ✗ **Don't copy another team's idea or content.** The proposal should represent your team's own work and understanding.
- ✗ **Don't include confidential credentials.** Never put passwords, API keys, tokens, private keys, or other secrets in the PDF.
- ✗ **Don't submit multiple conflicting versions.** Ensure the uploaded file is the final approved version.

6. FILE SIZE & PDF QUALITY CHECK

Check	Pass condition
File format	PDF (.pdf), unless the organizer specifies another format.
Maximum size	Must be within the stated limit; use ≤ 10 MB if 10 MB is the announced maximum.
File opens	Opens successfully on a different device/computer.
Pages	No blank, duplicate, corrupted, or unintended pages.
Text	Readable; no cut-off, overlap, or missing characters.
Images	Clear enough to read but compressed enough to keep file size within the limit.
Links	Any required links work and do not expose private credentials.
Final version	No comments, tracked changes, placeholders, or draft labels.

7. FINAL 5-MINUTE SUBMISSION CHECKLIST

- Team name is correct.
- All team member names are correct and consistently spelled.
- Chosen problem statement/topic is correct.
- Every mandatory template section is completed.
- Problem and proposed solution are clearly explained.
- Key features and MVP scope are identified.
- Technical approach/architecture is understandable.
- Innovation/USP is clearly stated.
- Expected impact is explained.
- No placeholder text such as “TBD”, “Lorem ipsum”, or “add image here” remains.
- No passwords, API keys, tokens, or confidential information are included.
- No copied/unauthorized material is included.
- PDF has been opened and checked page-by-page.
- PDF size is within the maximum allowed limit.
- Filename follows the required naming convention.
- Correct final PDF has been uploaded.
- Upload/submission confirmation has been saved or screenshot taken if applicable.

8. SUGGESTED FILE-NAMING CONVENTION

Recommended: TeamName_Hackathon_Qualifier.pdf

Example: CodeCrafters_Hackathon_Qualifier.pdf

If the organizers provide a naming convention, **always follow the organizer's convention instead.**

9. EVALUATOR-FRIENDLY SUBMISSION PRINCIPLE

Think of the PDF as a short pitch document. The evaluator should be able to answer these questions quickly: **What is the problem? Who has the problem? What is your solution? How does it work? Why is it useful or different? Can your team realistically build it? What impact will it create?** If these answers are clear, concise, and supported by a sensible technical approach, the qualifier submission will be much stronger.

Organizer Note: This checklist is a template. Event-specific rules, judging criteria, deadlines, file-size limits, page limits, naming conventions, and submission-platform requirements take priority over this document.